

Lilac-breasted roller

Coracias caudatus

Several similar kinds of rollers occupy Africa at various times of the year, distinguished by their tail shapes and minor color differences. The lilac chest is the identifying feature of the lilac-breasted roller, but it shares elongated tail streamers with the Abyssinian roller. It prefers bushy savanna and dry, open woodland, and perches prominently on trees. It is a very territorial and pugnacious bird.

Disperse after breeding

Lilac-breasted rollers build their nest in a cavity in a decaying stump or termite mound, which is left unlined. Both parents incubate the eggs for 18 days, and the chicks fly when they are 35 days old. Although lilac-breasted rollers do not migrate as such, they disperse widely after breeding, finding feeding territories which they defend individually or in pairs. Rollers are generalist and opportunistic feeders. They swoop to the ground to catch big insects, scorpions, centipedes, small reptiles, and occasionally, a small bird.

streaked white throat

- ↔ 13–14 in (33–36 cm)
- ⚖ 4–5 oz (113–142 g)
- ⊗ Common
- 🐛 Insects, scorpions, lizards
- 🏠 

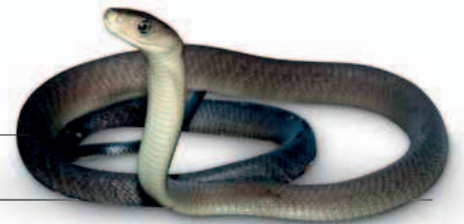


vivid spread wing

Black mamba

Dendroaspis polylepis

streamlined body with smooth scales



Strong, fast, agile, and deadly, the black mamba is Africa's longest venomous snake, and second only to the king cobra worldwide. Its "racing slither"—usually used to escape danger rather than to pursue prey—has been timed at 9 mph (14 km/h) and it may exceed 12 mph (20 km/h). Its somewhat drab olive, green, gray, or brown coloration has subdued, if any, markings.

Africa's deadliest snake

The black mamba is found in varied habitats, from rocky hills to coastal scrub. It rests at night in a home lair in a termite mound, small mammal burrow, tree root hollow, or rocky crevice. By day, the snake lurks in cover to strike out at passing victims. Its two fixed, hollow, upper fangs inject exceptionally toxic venom—it can kill a human in 30 minutes. The black mamba holds smaller prey for a few minutes until lifeless, but bites larger ones and withdraws, following them until the venom acts. The black mamba climbs well to hunt for nesting birds and squirrels. If threatened, it rears up, spreads its small "hood" cobra-fashion, opens its mouth, and hisses.



- ↔ 8–11 ft (2.4–3.4 m)
- ⚖ Up to 5 lb (2.3 kg)
- ⊗ Common
- 🐛 Small mammals, birds
- 🏠 



BLACK BITE

Hissing, gaping, tongue erect, upper fang tips visible—it is the dark interior of the mouth that gives the "black" mamba its name.